



CONTACT

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in [linkedin.com/in/sabaza](https://www.linkedin.com/in/sabaza)
⊕ Available Worldwide
▣ Citizenship: Dutch

CORE CAPABILITIES

- › Programming strategy & curation
- › Executive-producer creative direction
- › Speaker & content sourcing
- › Intimate, high-trust gatherings
- › Hospitality & guest experience
- › VVIP, family-office & founder audiences
- › Team leadership & development
- › Community-building through events

LANGUAGES

Arabic	Native
English	Native
French	Excellent
Spanish	Excellent
Dutch	Working
Polish	Working
Portuguese	Basic
Italian	Basic
Romanian	Basic

INTERESTS

- › Basketball coach; former national youth player.
- › Travelled across 100+ countries.
- › Active use of AI in event production and planning.

Sherif Abaza

Director of Experiential & Programming · Executive Producer ·
20+ Years of High-Trust Gatherings & Cultural Programming

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◆ Profile

Experiential director and executive producer with 20+ years building programming identities and producing the gatherings that turn audiences into communities. I think in outcomes, narratives and room energy — envisioning what an event should feel like before a single detail is booked — then curate the themes, speakers and guest experience that make it worth clearing a calendar for. From 8-person dinners to summits of tens of thousands, the craft is the same: the right people, the right room, and a reason to return.

I have founded and scaled a 140-person agency, directed three consecutive COP climate summits, and produced the inaugural Dubai International Film Festival — convening ministers, family-office principals, founders and cultural talent in high-trust, high-caliber settings. I own the full lifecycle: creative direction, speaker and content curation, hospitality and guest journey, budget and operations, and the post-event follow-through that deepens relationships. I lead and develop small senior teams, and I am as comfortable holding a private dinner as a main stage. Nine languages, delivery across 80+ countries.

◆ Professional Experience

Abaza Business Services · Global

Founder & Executive Producer 2019 – Present

- Curated and produced high-trust convenings around **COP27 (Egypt)**, **COP28 (UAE)**, and **COP29 (Azerbaijan)** — programming, speaker and stakeholder curation, and hospitality for ministers, principals and global leaders.
- Engaged as production and programming partner by leading experiential agencies — **Jack Morton**, **Shelton Fleming**, and **Impact XM** — shaping concepts, run-of-show and guest experience for international and Middle East programmes.
- Strategic advisor on event design, programming and guest experience for organisations convening discerning, senior audiences in intimate and large-format settings.
- Developed programming strategy for market-entry initiatives (including the NBA) with senior stakeholders across Europe and Africa.

Sphere Events and Communication · Dubai, UAE

Founder & Managing Director 2008 – 2018

- Founded and led a **140-person agency** producing **800+ experiences** — from intimate luxury dinners and private salons to speaker series and festivals for tens of thousands.
- Produced high-touch private gatherings and brand dinners for luxury clients including **Cartier and Porsche** — discretion, hospitality and an eye for detail for discerning guests.
- Owned agency P&L and led, mentored and developed senior multidisciplinary teams across production, design, logistics and client servicing.
- Curated programming, speakers and guest experience across conferences, brand communities and recurring event franchises (Street Nights, Marina Music Festival, Dubai Chocolate Festival).

Withlocals B.V. · Eindhoven, Netherlands

Chief Community Officer 2022 – 2026

Chief Growth Officer 2018 – 2022

- Built and led a global community of **2,000+ hosts across 80+ countries** — recruiting, curating and engaging a high-quality member network, and designing the experiences that turned a marketplace into a community.
- Owned member engagement, retention and belonging — using gatherings and programming as the instrument, not the output.
- Led the pivot to virtual and hybrid experiences, serving **70+ corporate clients** through a proprietary platform.

ASDAA Burson-Marsteller · Dubai, UAE

Senior Account Manager 2004 – 2006

- Key role producing the **inaugural Dubai International Film Festival** — talent curation, hospitality and cultural programming that placed Dubai on the international map.
- Brand experience programmes for Siemens, Adidas, and Hilton across the Middle East.

FrontFlip (me360) · Kansas City, USA / MENA

CEO, Middle East & North Africa 2010 – 2015

- Co-led regional operations for a community and loyalty startup; raised **USD 1.8M** in early-stage funding and built a 35-person team across 6+ markets.

Sundance Events · Dubai, UAE

Business Development & Operations Manager 2006 – 2008

- Business development and operational delivery for corporate and government clients across the UAE — the foundation for founding Sphere Events.

◆ Leadership & Development

AIESEC International

Various Leadership Roles 1999 – 2004

- Progressive leadership including Local Committee President and National Support Team roles — building and leading communities through cross-cultural exchange programmes.

◆ Education

Bachelor of Computer Engineering

Arab Academy for Science, Technology and Maritime Transport · Alexandria, Egypt